

How to Bake a Cake – Beginner's Guide

Lesson 7: Simple Frosting & Filling

Simple Frosting & Filling - Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **Buttercream Basics** – Emulsifying butter with powdered sugar to create a smooth, stable frosting.
2. **Whipped Cream Filling** – Incorporating air into heavy cream for a light, airy topping or layer.
3. **Ingredient Ratios** – Understanding the typical butter to sugar and cream to sweetener proportions for consistent results.
4. **Temperature & Mixing Techniques** – How butter softness, cream temperature, and mixing speed affect texture.
5. **Flavor & Stabilization Options** – Adding extracts, cocoa, fruit purées, or stabilizers to customize and prolong shelf life.

Summary

Buttercream is the workhorse frosting in home baking. The classic “1 /cup butter + 2 /cups powdered sugar” ratio yields a medium stiff buttercream that spreads easily, holds its shape for piping, and can be flavored with vanilla, cocoa, citrus zest, or liqueurs. The key is to start with softened (but not melted) butter, beat it until light and fluffy, then gradually add sifted powdered sugar while continuing to beat. A splash of milk, cream, or a flavored liquid helps achieve the desired consistency.

Whipped cream filling is a simple, airy alternative for cakes, cupcakes, and pastries. Heavy whipping cream (“e /35 /% fat) is chilled, then beaten until soft peaks form; a small amount of powdered sugar (“H /1–2 /Tbsp per cup of cream) and vanilla extract enhance flavor. For stability—especially in warm environments—add a stabilizer such as a teaspoon of powdered gelatin, a pinch of cream of tartar, or a commercial whipped cream stabilizer. Whipped cream provides a fresh, less sweet contrast to rich buttercream and works well in layered desserts.

Both frostings rely on proper temperature control, gradual ingredient incorporation, and appropriate mixing speed. Mastering these fundamentals lets you adapt recipes quickly, troubleshoot texture problems, and experiment with flavors.

Important Points

- **Butter Temperature:** Use butter softened to ~65 °F (18–20 °C). Too soft = greasy; too firm = lumpy.
- **Powdered Sugar:** Sift before adding to avoid lumps and ensure a silky finish.
- **Mixing Speed:** Start low to combine, then increase to medium high for aeration. Over mixing can cause a grainy texture.
- **Adjusting Consistency:**
 - Too thick !' add a tablespoon of milk/cream at a time.
 - Too thin !' add more powdered sugar (1 /Tbsp increments).

- **Whipped Cream Tips:**

- Keep cream, bowl, and beaters chilled (30 /min or more).
- Stop beating at soft peaks; continue to stiff peaks only if needed for piping.
- Stabilizer ratios: 1 /tsp gelatin (dissolved in 2 /Tbsp warm water) per 2 /cups cream.

- **Flavor Add Ins:** Vanilla (½ /tsp per cup butter), cocoa (2 /Tbsp per cup butter), citrus zest (1 /tsp), liqueur (1 /Tbsp). Add liquids gradually to avoid thinning.

- **Storage:** Buttercream can sit at room temp ("d /70 /°F) for 1 /day; refrigerated for up to 1 /week. Whipped cream is best used within 4 /hours unless stabilized.

Examples

1. Classic Vanilla Buttercream

Ingredients

- 1 /cup (2 /sticks) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 /cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 1 /tsp pure vanilla extract
- 2–3 /Tbsp heavy cream or milk
- Pinch of salt

Method

1. Beat butter on medium speed until pale and fluffy ("H /2 /min).
2. Reduce speed, add powdered sugar a third at a time, mixing until incorporated.
3. Add vanilla, salt, and 2 /Tbsp cream; beat on high until smooth.
4. If too stiff, add the remaining tablespoon of cream, 1 /Tbsp at a time, until spreadable.

***Why it works:** The 1:2 butter to sugar ratio gives a balanced sweetness and structure, while the cream adjusts spreadability without making the frosting runny.

2. Stabilized Whipped Cream Filling

Ingredients

- 1 /cup (240 /ml) heavy whipping cream, chilled
- 2 /Tbsp powdered sugar
- ½ /tsp vanilla extract
- 1 /tsp unflavored gelatin
- 2 /Tbsp cold water

Method

1. Sprinkle gelatin over cold water; let bloom 5 /min. Heat gently (microwave 5 /sec) until dissolved; cool to room temperature.
2. In a chilled bowl, begin whipping cream on medium speed.
3. When soft peaks form, add powdered sugar and vanilla; continue whipping.
4. Slowly drizzle the cooled gelatin solution while whipping on medium high until stiff peaks form.

***Why it works:** Gelatin creates a network that traps air bubbles, giving the cream stability for several hours, perfect for layered cakes or cupcakes that sit out before serving.

Quick Review

1. What is the standard butter to powdered sugar ratio for a basic buttercream?
2. Why must butter be softened but not melted when making buttercream?
3. Name two methods to stabilize whipped cream for longer holding time.
4. How can you thin a buttercream that has become too stiff?
5. What temperature range is ideal for storing buttercream at room temperature?

Further Reading

- **Chocolate Buttercream Variations** – incorporating melted chocolate, cocoa powder, and espresso.
- **Swiss & Italian Meringue Buttercreams** – for smoother, less sweet frostings.
- **Fruit Puree Fillings** – balancing acidity and sweetness in whipped cream based fillings.
- **Frosting Troubleshooting Guide** – grainy texture, curdling, and separation solutions.
- **Food Safety for Dairy Based Frostings** – shelf life, refrigeration, and contamination prevention.

